



A SLOW CAMERA exposure records vehicle traffic at night on Sunset Boulevard in West Hollywood.

GINA FERRAZZI Los Angeles Times

A way to get drivers to slow down

Speed cameras have changed behavior in San Francisco. Soon they'll be used in L.A.

By KAREN GARCIA

A year after the installation of speed cameras in San Francisco, drivers in the city are slowing down, data show, and experts say the technology could have a similar effect once cameras are installed in Los Angeles.

According to a one-year analysis of data collected from San Francisco's 33 camera locations and other traffic-sensing equipment, excessive speeding — defined as drivers going more than 10 mph above the speed limit — dropped nearly 80%. The number of repeat offenders dropped, too.

Roadway and urban engineering experts say San Francisco's findings are on par with the success of other communities across the nation that have already implemented speed camera technology.

"The results are clear," San Francisco Mayor Daniel Lurie said in a statement. "Drivers are changing their behavior."

When Los Angeles finishes installing 125 cameras throughout its 15 districts by the end of July, the city hopes the implementation will lead to a similar significant reduction in speeding drivers. According to experts, here are some takeaways L.A. can glean from its Bay Area counterpart:

San Francisco and Los Angeles are just two of six California cities participating in a five-year pilot program that was authorized by a bill signed into law in 2023. The goal is to combat speeding and an alarming rise in traffic-related deaths by

[See Cameras, A8]

Iran war gives recycled plastics surprise boost

By Susanne Rust

As the war with Iran sends the price of virgin plastic skyward, speculation is growing as to whether recycled plastic could finally have its day after struggling for years to gain a greater foothold among manufacturers.

Not since the collapse of the global recycling market in 2018 and the COVID-19 pandemic has the world faced as big a shock to the production and sale of plastic products — all of which are made from oil and gas.

Today, roughly half of the global ethylene and polyethylene supply is stranded, constrained, or directly affected by the halt to commercial shipping through the Strait of Hormuz — a crucial transit point for 20% of the world's crude.

Typically, recycled plastic is more expensive than virgin plastic. But in April, that calculus began to shift in many markets as the cost of plastics used in car parts, toys, bottles, food containers, cosmetics and many other products began to soar.

"Recycled plastics are having a major moment," said Matt Slutzker, a principal analyst with Wood Mackenzie, a global research and consulting firm.

War in the Middle East already has affected the supply of plastic packaging significantly, according to Slutzker, who noted that Asian refineries and upstream facilities are unable to get the material they need for processing.

In Western [See Plastics, A8]



ANSHUMAN POYREKAR Hindustan Times

AN OIL tanker that exited the Strait of Hormuz is in Mumbai on Thursday.

ICE deportee now stranded

Agency insists it can't get Cuban back from Mexico

By BRITTNY MEJIA

The U.S. government had no trouble deporting Lazaro Romero León to Mexico in February, despite a California federal judge's order that the Cuban national stay in this country.

The problem now, government officials claim, is getting him back.

First, Immigration and Customs Enforcement considered putting Romero León on a plane from the Mexican state of Chiapas to

the U.S. But U.S. officials say the Mexican government won't accept his identification documents to board a flight.

Then, ICE tried to put him on a bus — the \$350 ticket was paid by Romero León's deputy federal public defender. But long before he reached the border, his attorney said, he was pulled off the bus by Mexican authorities for not having sufficient documents and placed into a detention center.

Now, government officials say they're talking to

the Coast Guard about bringing him by boat.

The complicated, two-month saga to return Romero León was laid bare during a court hearing in downtown Los Angeles on April 23, during which a judge excoriated the government for not complying with his order to immediately return the 59-year-old and threatening to issue contempt sanctions.

"I'm going to need it to be elevated and to have higher channels get this done," U.S. District Judge Hernán D.

[See Stranded, A7]

For 'Chonkers,' a big chunk of attention

By SUMMER LIN

It's a sight to behold — the 1-ton sea lion peeking his head out of the water in San Francisco Bay and triggering a panic as other sea lions hustle to get out of the way.

There's a lot of barking, and suddenly the big fella hops onto the wood platform, sending the other pin-nipeds jostling for a new spot in the sun or diving back into the water.

At Pier 39, the sea lion known as "Chonkers" is king, and his sheer size and



HAVEN DALEY Associated Press

"CHONKERS," a massive Steller sea lion, has been drawing large crowds to Pier 39 in San Francisco.

proximity to a major tourist hub has made him a beloved viral animal obsession, on par with recent celebrities Moo Deng and P-22.

"I saw on the news about Chonkers in Atlanta, Ga., and I came all the way to San Francisco to see him," one visitor told CBS News.

"I'm looking for the big one," another person said. "Looking for Chonkers."

Chonkers is a Steller sea lion, which is a heftier variety of the species compared to his California sea lion counterparts.

[See 'Chonkers,' A8]

Record shutdown of Homeland Security is over

Funding bill averts more airport turmoil but omits money for immigration agenda.

By LISA MASCARO

WASHINGTON — President Trump swiftly signed bipartisan legislation Thursday funding much of the Department of Homeland Security, but not its immigration enforcement operations, after it won final approval in the House, ending the longest agency shutdown in history.

The White House had warned that temporary funding Trump had tapped to pay Transportation Security Administration and other agency personnel would "soon run out," and that sparked new threats of disruptions for travelers at airports. Homeland Security has been without routine funds since Feb. 14, causing hardship for workers, though much of Trump's immigration agenda that is central to the dispute is being funded separately.

The package had languished in the House despite being approved without opposition in the Senate in March, as Republicans re-

volted, forcing a separate path for the immigration funds. Once that launched this week, it cleared the way to fund the rest of Homeland Security, whose employees risked lost paychecks in May.

"It is about damn time," said Rep. Rosa DeLauro of Connecticut, the top Democrat on the House Appropriations Committee, who proposed the bipartisan bill more than 70 days ago.

The House swiftly voted by voice Thursday, without a formal roll call, to pass the measure. It brought an abrupt end to the standoff that began months ago after Trump's deadly immigration crackdown in Minneapolis launched a reckoning on Capitol Hill over the money being sent to fuel the president's agenda.

The movement in Congress comes as Homeland Security is under intense scrutiny after Trump ousted Kristi Noem as the department's leader, installing Oklahoma Sen. Markwayne Mullin in the middle of the shutdown. The agency counts about 260,000 employees across the TSA, the Coast Guard, the Federal Emergency Management Agency and other operations.

[See Homeland, A6]

New nominee for surgeon general

After Casey Means' path stalled in Senate, Trump picks Nicole Saphier, a radiologist.

By ALI SWENSON AND MEG KINNARD

WASHINGTON — President Trump said Thursday he's nominating radiologist and former Fox News Channel contributor Dr. Nicole Saphier for surgeon general after Dr. Casey Means' path forward stalled in the Senate over questions about her experience and her stance on vaccines.

In a social media post, Trump said he would nominate Saphier, whom he called "a STAR physician who has spent her career guiding women facing breast cancer through their diagnosis and treatment." Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. complimented the nomination, calling Saphier "a long-time warrior for the MAHA movement."

But at least in one instance, she hasn't been in lockstep with Trump's thoughts on health policy, telling the Associated Press in September that his cautions about pregnant women taking Tylenol were over-

simplistic and "patronizing."

Saphier is director of breast imaging at Memorial Sloan Kettering Monmouth, according to her profile on the New York-based institution's website. She has a doctor of medicine degree from Ross University School of Medicine in Barbados along with fellowships at the Mayo Clinic, the profile said.

She also used the phrase "Make America Healthy Again" before Kennedy claimed it for his political movement. It was the title of a book she wrote in 2020 that criticized government handling of healthcare and the Affordable Care Act.

Means' withdrawal came after her tense exchanges with lawmakers of both parties threw into question whether she could secure enough votes to advance out of the Senate health committee.

Her nomination had languished since her confirmation hearing in late February, even as activists from the MAHA movement orchestrated a push to support her bid by surging phone calls to Republican Sens. Lisa Murkowski of Alaska and Susan Collins of Maine. They both indicated reservations with the pick.

[See Nominee, A6]

Mexico refuses to extradite officials

President Sheinbaum denounces U.S. indictments of Sinaloa governor and other authorities. **WORLD, A3**

Prosecutors lay out murder case

Court filings allege singer D4vd bought a chain saw to use on the victim, who was found dead in his car. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

State sees rise in global investment

The number of foreign-owned businesses rose 4% last year despite U.S. trade disruption, a report finds. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 77/57. **B6**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



7 85944 00200 5



ALISHA JUCEVIC For The Times

A 7-YEAR-OLD poses with a hired performer.

L.A.'s in-demand entertainers

Move over, Elsa. "KPop Demon Hunters" have become the hottest offering for kids' parties. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Markets A12
Opinion Voices A13